

Inspection of London Borough of Sutton local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 16 June to 20 June 2025

Lead inspector: Gareth Dakin, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Good
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of children care leavers	Good
Overall effectiveness	Good

The majority of children and families in Sutton receive the help, protection and care that they need. Most services to children and care leavers have been maintained and improved on since the last inspection in 2021. The senior leadership team along with strong, political and corporate support has injected energy and pace to facilitate improvements to ensure that children and care leavers benefit from effective social care practice.

Senior leaders' ambition for children and care leavers through relationship-based practice, the quality of direct work with children and care leavers, and a focus on meaningful help are areas of strength.

Practice, assurance and governance arrangements are mostly comprehensive and purposeful. Nevertheless, for a small number of children in specific cohorts, these arrangements are not consistently effective. This has led to a small minority of children not receiving the timely help and protections they need.

What needs to improve?

- The quality and consistency of response to children who are looked after who go missing from home (Outcome 4, National Framework).
- The effectiveness of the initial response to children who are at risk of physical harm (Outcome 1, National Framework).
- The quality and robustness of leaders and managers' oversight of discrete areas of practice where there is not effective social work (Enabler 2, National Framework).

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. The majority of children in Sutton receive effective and responsive help and protection.
2. The Targeted Early Help Service (TEHS) offers effective support that helps children thrive. Leaders have significantly reduced the waiting period for an assessment. Some families still wait too long for services, but this is communicated with them, and most families receive support or signposting during this period. Practitioners understand well-established step-up arrangements; this allows for appropriate escalation when children's needs increase or risks emerge. Skilled, specialist support workers based in the social work locality teams deliver intensive, bespoke and effective packages of support to children who step down from a plan or after a social work assessment of children's needs.
3. Parents and children who access the parenting group programme experience meaningful and transformative support delivered through targeted interventions. Parents are empowered to support others in the community by becoming parent volunteers and supporting more families at the early help stage.
4. Most children referred to the Children's First Contact Service, Sutton's front door, receive a timely and effective response. For the vast majority of children, decision-making is appropriate. Children's levels of need and risk are considered carefully to decide the right course of action. However, for a small number of children, the response to allegations they make of physical harm results in them being left in situations of unassessed risk and waiting too long before they receive the help and the support they might need.
5. When children need help and protection out of hours, social work responses are prompt and proportionate. Effective handovers of information to daytime staff result in timely follow-up the next working day.
6. When safeguarding concerns are identified, the majority of decisions to progress to a strategy meeting are appropriate. Strategy meetings are timely

for most children and well attended by relevant agencies. These meetings lead to well-considered decisions regarding the steps required to explore and identify the needs and risks to children. Assertive interim safety planning is collaborative with families where appropriate, and multi-agency information-sharing and accountability leads to a proportionate response and relevant actions that help to protect children.

7. Children's assessments are sensitively written, comprehensive and are informed by children and their parents' views and reflect their needs. Assessments also reflect the views of other agencies involved. Assessments reflect children's histories, include children's voices, and most result in helpful next steps stemming from clear analysis.
8. Children are visited in line with their presenting needs. Social workers use a range of creative communication tools to ensure that children's views and lived experiences influence and shape their plans.
9. Effective partnership working, co-ordinated through child protection conferences, core groups and reviews, contribute to the analysis and reduction of risk for children. Most children's child protection and child-in-need plans are specific, measurable and are regularly updated to reflect changing needs. Children and families' views are captured effectively, which enables plans to be individualised and focused.
10. Children in the pre-proceedings stage of the Public Law Outline benefit from timely and well-managed intervention. Specialist assessment and family involvement is prioritised, with creative packages of support often enabling children to remain safely at home.
11. Support and services for children with a child-in-need or child protection plan that go missing from home have strengthened since the last inspection. Management oversight is robust and, when children do go missing, they are met with a timely and well-coordinated response. Exploratory and holistic return home interviews help reduce the likelihood of future episodes and intelligence is used to develop trigger plans.
12. Children at risk of exploitation benefit from robust systems for early identification, information-sharing and coordinated action to disrupt emerging risks across and beyond local boundaries. Persistence and high levels of involvement, working at the child and family's pace, underpin this work. A trauma-informed approach manages and reduces risk effectively.
13. Leaders have very clear arrangements to identify and respond to children who are missing from education or who are electively home educated. Effective tracking and monitoring systems ensure that vulnerable home-educated children are safeguarded.
14. Disabled children have thoughtful, knowledgeable and skilled social workers who understand their needs well. This leads to children receiving services that

support them to make progress in their lives. Transitional support is planned well in advance of adulthood, and this reduces anxiety for children approaching adulthood.

15. The local authority designated officer (LADO) responds promptly to allegations made against adults who work with children. Consistent and clear thresholds ensure that allegations against staff and volunteers are responded to, and meetings are convened where required and are well attended. This helps to safeguard children in Sutton.
16. A very small number of children are identified as being privately fostered in Sutton. Awareness-raising work continues across the community to improve the identification of these arrangements. Leaders have acknowledged the need for enhanced oversight of these arrangements and took steps to address this during the inspection. However, it is too early to test the effectiveness of these changes.
17. Children's assessments do not always identify and consider the specific needs of children that arise from their role as young carers. Leaders are aware of this and have initiatives in place to help workers better acknowledge young carers, their caring status and how their associated needs are being responded to, but it is too soon to see the impact of this for children.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

18. When they are not able to live safely at home, children come into the care of the local authority when it is in their best interests to do so and most enter care at the appropriate time. Social workers assess kinship carers promptly to enable children to live in their family/friend networks when it is safe to do so. When children enter care, social workers take time to understand their needs and their lived experiences well through thorough social work assessments. Most children in care enjoy positive experiences. They make good progress in many aspects of their lives and most achieve well from their respective starting points.
19. When children come into care, plans for permanence are identified early. Managers, social workers and independent reviewing officers consider the range of permanence options for children concurrently before deciding what the best option is for each individual child. There is robust tracking of children's care plans. Once decisions are made to issue care proceedings, these decisions are timely and informed by needs and risk. This is supporting children to be safer. The family court and CAFCASS report positively about the work professionals in Sutton undertake with children and their families. They say that the 'right children are coming into care at the right time'.
20. 'All About Me' assessments inform comprehensive and clear care plans that are purposeful and individualised, and they provide a lovely snapshot into a child's life. As a result, most children live in stable homes that meet their needs and

where they thrive. Children live with their brothers and sisters if this is right for them, with increased support if there is a risk of breakdown.

21. Care plans for children are tailored to the child's needs. Plans are child focused and reflect the wishes and feelings of children well. Children's needs arising from their race, religion, ethnicity or culture are consistently considered when planning for children in care.
22. Independent reviewing officers are visible in children's lives. All-about-me review meetings take place regularly. Children are actively participating and leading in their reviews and their voices are heard. Where there are difficulties in children's participation, they have access to a range of support and advocacy to enable them to be involved in key decisions.
23. Children are supported to keep in touch with their familial networks and maintain connections with important people in their lives. This helps children to maintain and strengthen relationships and promotes their sense of identity.
24. Risks to children in care are mostly recognised and responded to. Practitioners work collaboratively with children's networks, and this is helping to protect them from harm. However, for those children who go missing from care, the response is not robust enough for children.
25. When children who are looked after go missing or their whereabouts are unknown, there is an inconsistent range of coordinated responses, curiosity and care afforded to them. The line of sight for these vulnerable children is unclear and as a result, a small number of children receive inconsistent help and support at times when they need it most. This has been acknowledged by leaders, who have reported that they will review this area of practice and assure themselves that the right children are getting the right support at the right time.
26. Sutton has developed a range of high-quality services to enhance the health and well-being offer for children and care leavers. An effective in-house therapeutic service, staffed by an expanding and committed multi-disciplinary team, offers targeted interventions to children and care leavers. Skilled staff help promote children's mental health, resilience and recovery. As a result, children are receiving better help and a timelier response.
27. Time-sensitive reviews of children's permanence plans result in an increase in planned exits from care via special guardianship orders or the ending of care orders. For children exiting care, decisions are informed by timely and comprehensive assessments. Skilled social workers work closely with parents, families, children and the wider professional network to support safe and appropriate exits from care for children in line with their needs.
28. Social workers know their children very well. They take time to get to know children and establish positive and helpful relationships. Visits are regular and purposeful. Social workers articulate children's needs well and are purposeful in

their work and aspirations for children. When direct work is completed with children, it is focused and delivered with purpose. Practitioners do not shy away from discussing difficult topics with children who have experienced significant trauma in their earlier lives, and this supports them to better understand the experiences of children.

29. Most children live in stable homes where they make good progress. When placements are at risk of breakdown, prompt stability meetings help professionals to identify what support is needed to help children to remain in their homes. When children do move homes, these are mostly planned in a child-focused way. This provides children with time to understand the reasons for the move and support them to settle.
30. Children in care do well in school, supported by effective virtual school arrangements and the designated safeguarding lead network. They enjoy good health and have lots of opportunities to follow their interests and hobbies. This is enabling children to make progress and enrich their lives.
31. Social workers in the disabled children's team know each child well and are attuned to their needs. They support and encourage children, including those who do not communicate verbally, to have a say in what is important to them. This is informing children's plans and helping them to have better experiences.
32. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children are well supported in Sutton. They are provided with suitable accommodation that meets their individual needs. They are helped to gain independent living skills and have access to appropriate healthcare such as a GP, dentist and opticians. Progress for these children is evident in their achievements, as they make good educational and community-based progress that is promoting positive experiences.
33. A very small number of children are placed in unregistered children's homes. There is strong oversight of these unlawful arrangements. Leaders regularly monitor the welfare of children living in these settings and work with commissioners to find registered homes for children. Enhanced visiting and oversight from social workers and care staff ensure that children are supported while alternative arrangements are made.
34. Leaders know there is more to do with the recruitment of adopters and foster carers. They have a strong marketing strategy in place and are working with partners to enhance this offer. There is a commitment to keeping Sutton children in the borough, supporting them to be in or near their community.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: good

35. Care leavers receive an attentive service from dedicated personal advisers (PAs) who genuinely care about them. PAs are allocated in good time, enabling meaningful and trusted relationships to develop as care leavers progress through adulthood. PAs are persistent in developing relationships with those

care leavers who are hard to reach so they are more likely to turn to their PA when in need.

36. The majority of care leavers in Sutton live in safe, stable accommodation which meets their needs. Most care leavers progress well in education and employment, and are supported according to their individual needs. Additional support to live independently and maintain tenancies is tailored to the young person's needs. PAs are staunch advocates for young people's accommodation needs, and work well with housing colleagues. However, some housing decisions are inconsistent and do not always consider young people's vulnerabilities. Leaders are taking steps to address this.
37. Care leavers are well supported to develop and maintain links with their family and friends' networks. PAs consider the level of support offered by families, and family group meetings are used routinely. This demonstrates how the importance of these relationships is an active consideration for PAs.
38. Care leavers are involved with and shape their own individual pathway plans, and most pathway plans are comprehensive and accessible. Plans reflect the day-to-day life for care leavers, highlight their priorities and are aspirational. Plans contain clear actions, which help care leavers successfully navigate early adulthood. Plans are regularly reviewed to remain relevant and reflect progress made.
39. Care leavers benefit from a developed local offer in Sutton. PAs understand the offer, and this is reflected in pathway planning and in the support offered. However, some young people told us that they can struggle to access and fully understand the offer and their entitlements. Leaders have acknowledged this and are exploring steps to improve communication and maximise the awareness of the local offer.
40. Sutton has recognised care leaver status as being a protected characteristic. This recognises the additional vulnerabilities of care leavers and is providing the foundations for wider corporate responsibility and accountability for care leavers across the borough. Decisions made across the council and partners are now explicitly considering the impact to care leavers as part of their corporate parenting commitment. The impact of this is being seen in areas related to housing and employment opportunities, and leaders know there is still more to do to embed this approach.
41. For most care leavers, risk is identified and addressed by PAs who understand their care leavers well. Help and support is provided in a timely way and, for most care leavers, they receive a consistent service that supports them to live safer lives.
42. PAs provide a sensitive and attuned response to care leavers who are parents. They provide practical and emotional support and know care leavers' children well.

43. Care leavers who are former asylum-seeking children are well supported by PAs, who are sensitive to their stories, trauma and cultural and religious needs. They are helped in their applications to remain in the UK, supported to learn English, and to make connections with those with similar experiences. Care leavers are actively supported post 21, if they want this, although PAs are conscious not to create dependency and they reduce support when the young person is ready for this.
44. Most care leavers in custody receive a consistent response and are well supported up to the age of 25. However, for a small number of care leavers, it is not clear that they receive the support and advice that they need. For these care leavers, gaps in recording and management oversight did not evidence work being done to improve the support and experiences of these care leavers.
45. PAs are mostly proactive in supporting care leavers to access employment, education and training, helped by a specialist EET worker. Many care leavers make good progress.
46. Care leavers' achievements are celebrated. They enjoy a range of activities to enhance their personal development, and to bring them together to have fun and make connections. This is supporting care leavers to develop social networks and become more independent and confident in their communities.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: good

47. Sutton benefits from an established, motivated and forward-thinking leadership team that is focused on improving the experience of children and care leavers. Leaders have set out a clear, strategic vision for service development and have influenced a range of practice improvements across children's services.
48. Leaders understand service areas in Sutton well, and these services are delivering effectively to children and care leavers. However, over the course of the inspection, inspectors identified some discrete areas of practice that were not clearly understood by leaders. This includes decision-making at the front door when children allege physical harm, children in care who go missing and services to children who are privately fostered. For these children, practice, assurance and governance arrangements and structures need to be more effective. Once identified, leaders took swift and proportionate action during the inspection to address these areas of weaker practice.
49. Corporate and political support is focused on children. Leaders understand the needs of children in the borough and are committed to improving their experiences. An engaged chief executive and lead member hold the DCS to account and provide challenge and support, and there is a shared focus on improving outcomes for children and care leavers.

50. Developing impactful services is a key priority for leaders, and this is supported by investment in children's social care that has delivered a range of good services to children and care leavers. Sutton has a strong track record of implementing multiple new initiatives effectively and these are having a positive impact on children's experiences. By taking a 'one council' approach, investments have been made in areas such as the opening of new children's homes, a therapeutic hub that offers a specialist emotional and mental health service to children and care leavers and consultation to staff, and the Kickstart futures & Joint Housing protocol for care leavers.
51. These developments, along with a range of other initiatives, are helping to improve the experiences and opportunities for children and care leavers, which is enabling them to make better progress.
52. Increased workforce capacity and investment underline a commitment to achieving priorities and improving outcomes for children. A sound understanding and investment in placement sufficiency means that more children are being cared for in and close to their home area, although a small number of children still reside in unlawful unregistered children's homes.
53. The voice of children and care leavers is a priority in Sutton, and the corporate parenting board reflects this. The effectiveness of the board is promoting an ethos of high support and high challenge towards senior leaders and politicians. Achievements such as the 'one council' approach to care leavers have led to their profile being raised and celebrated. This, alongside a commitment to care leaver status being a protected characteristic, is enabling change and improving help and support for care leavers across the borough.
54. Senior leaders have welcomed scrutiny and challenge from safeguarding partners. Relationships are strong and mutually challenging, and partners work together to effect change for children and care leavers. Leaders and managers are reflective and use learning from practice and feedback to improve the experiences and care of children.
55. Leaders are focused on developing their approaches to a national reform agenda. Some progress has been made such as the opening of family hubs, more help to keep children in their family networks, improving support to care leavers and increasing the number of homes for children. These changes are being monitored for effectiveness, and leaders are committed to further investment to enable them to deliver on the reforms purposefully, in line with their service vision and to minimise disruption to service quality and delivery.
56. Embedded quality assurance frameworks help leaders to understand most children's experiences in Sutton. These frameworks have not been consistently effective in alerting leaders to the quality of practice in some discrete areas.
57. Strong leadership has set the foundations for practice to be trauma informed and relational in its approach. This is palpable in the day-to-day work between

social care staff, children, care leavers and their family networks. Workers understand and advocate for children and care leavers with agility and are committed to supporting children and care leavers. They put impressive energy into building purposeful relationships with children and care leavers. This is leading to strengthening relationships with staff, who know children well and understand their individual circumstances.

58. Management oversight and supervision in Sutton is mostly regular, reflective, comprehensive and of good quality. Practitioners report this to be helpful and accessible in providing challenge and direction. However, for a small number of children in specific circumstances, supervision does not offer sufficient rigour and challenge to consistently identify and reduce risk to children.
59. Staff told inspectors that they enjoy working in Sutton. They report a culture and leadership that is supportive, visible and accessible. Staff understand the ethos and vision set out by leaders and feel valued. Training is tailored to challenge and improve practice and staff feel supported with opportunities to develop.



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